

BEST BUY
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SEPTEMBER 2007

an excellent 17-inch monitor (the HP VP-17).

If you want something a little different-looking, the curvy and very grey LG XDZ should be worth considering. It's a very capable performer with a Core 2 Duo processor (E4300). It also comes with a very good LCD.

It's rather plain-looking, but the Compaq Presario SG3063IL does have a decent set of components and a noteworthy bundle—just buy a bigger hard drive.

MEDIA CENTRE DESKTOPS

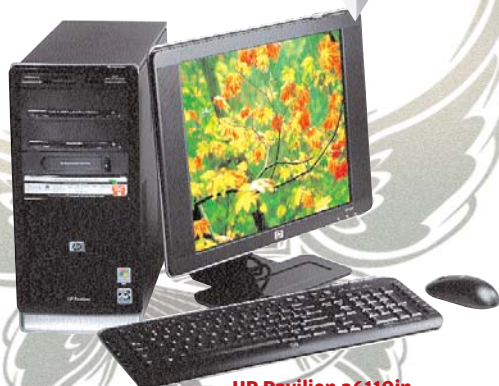
Home Entertainment With A Personal Touch

These PCs are also called Home Theatre PCs (HTPCs). Aimed at making your DVD player obsolete, such PCs have the added benefits of a full-fledged DVD / VCD / audio player, and all PC functionality is present as well. Most HTPCs include wireless remote controls, much like a home theatre system. They may also have wireless keyboards and mice to improve ergonomics. Finally, a good HTPC should have a large widescreen—a must for HD content. A decent graphics card also ensures skip-free playback, particularly of HD content.

Features

Why Didn't They Bundle A Sofa Too?

Although a media centre is usually associated with a remote control and a large screen, all our contestants break the mould in some way or the other... The unconventional contender in more ways than one was Acer's Aspire L310. By far the sexiest Desktop we've tested here, this stunner has an unbelievably tiny footprint, and stands just over a foot tall. A great-looking silver-grey finish complements the exceptional

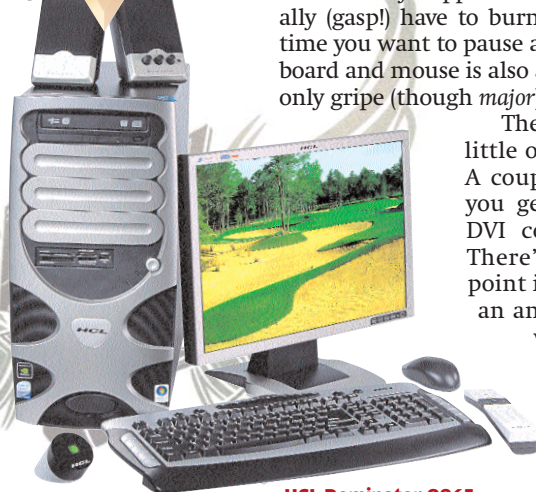


HP Pavilion a6110in
Great monitor & build quality

build quality. Your desktop will draw covetous glances with this sitting atop it... The fact that Acer provided the largest monitor in the whole shootout to partner this baby (a 22-inch widescreen LCD) speaks of its HTPC intent. Moreover, the monitor has a reed-thin bezel—very desirable.

HCL's Dominator will do just that—*dominate* your desktop. This was the largest HTPC cabinet we've seen. Bulky isn't good as far as anything media centre goes—to its credit, the cabinet is well-built and quite spacious. The third competitor in this category was another HCL—the Beanstalk Classic Z944. Slightly larger than the Acer L310, it comes decked in piano black. However, we didn't like the looks too much: glossy black looks good on curvy products. This one was a touch too angular. HCL bundles the same 19-inch widescreen monitor with both models.

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HCL Dominator Q965
Four cores on a rampage!

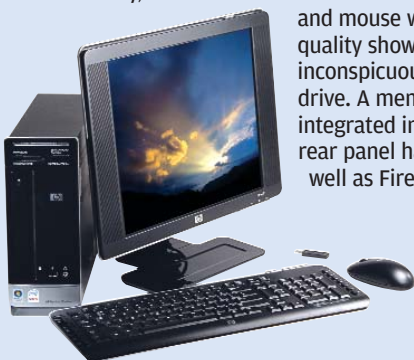
Hey! Where's The Popcorn?

Acer shockingly lets the Aspire L310 go without a remote control—criminal, really, considering Windows XP Media Center Edition is bundled. This severely cripples the couch potato—you actually (gasp!) have to burn precious calories each time you want to pause a movie. No wireless keyboard and mouse is also a shame—and this is our only gripe (though *major*) with this Desktop.

The software bundle is a little on the skimpy side, too. A couple of driver CDs is all you get. What we liked was DVI connectivity for video. There's a wireless access point in-built so WLAN is just an antenna away... Acer provides all the cables necessary to get you started. Unfortunately, the shrink in size comes at a price: there's a bulky power adapter to contend with, not very smart for your

The HP Pavilion s3180in

The first thing that'll strike you about the Pavilion s3180in is the extremely good use of piano black on the front bezel. Thanks to superbly-designed rubber feet, this cabinet won't budge on your desk, and is surprisingly heavy for a small-form-factor PC. The monitor supplied is the excellent VP 17, also finished in glossy black—unfortunately, it's not widescreen. HP bundles a wireless keyboard and mouse with this desktop, and the quality shows. The USB module is tiny, inconspicuous, and looks like a thumb drive. A memory card reader is integrated into the front bezel. The rear panel has Digital Audio Out as well as FireWire connectivity.



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Powered by a Core 2 Duo E4300 and with 1 GB of memory, the s3180in cuts through most regular applications like a hot knife through butter. What we really liked was the large hard disk—250 GB is good (500 GB would have been fantastic). This PC is up to HD movie playback, but we'd have loved to see a larger widescreen monitor. Rest assured, though—everyone except image editing professionals and gamers are well-covered.

The real appeal of this Desktop lies in its diminutive size—only the Acer Aspire L310 is smaller—and its classy looks. There's that distinctive upmarket feel to the entire system that bespeaks status, and visitors will definitely take another look at this atop your desk!

If you're looking at something that gives solid bang for the buck, we suggest you look elsewhere—the same specifications will be available for a cheaper price point. At Rs 45,990, the s3180in is pricey—not value for money, but rather value for the moneyed! If you're looking for a classy Desktop PC that'll save you loads of room, look at this—but not before looking at the Aspire L310!